

Chad



Area 495,755 sq miles
(1,284,000 sq km)
Population 11.5 million
Capital N'Djamena
Currency CFA franc
Official languages Arabic
and French
Life expectancy 51 years

This landlocked nation in north central Africa is a largely semidesert country. It gained independence from France in 1960. Since then, Chad has had a chaotic history, with civil wars and military coups. As a result, the country has an underdeveloped economy. Recently, large oil deposits were discovered in the southern Doba region.



Cameroon



Area 183,553 sq miles
(475,400 sq km)
Population 20 million
Capital Yaoundé
Currency CFA franc
Official languages French
and English
Life expectancy 50 years

Cameroon is a forested country located on the central west African coast. It was formed in 1961 when two former British and French colonies came together. Ethnically diverse, Cameroon is home to about 230 groups, the largest being the Bamileke. Cameroon has one of the highest literacy rates in Africa.



▲ CARVED WOODEN MASK
Masks hold great significance in traditional African culture. This one is from the Cross River region of Cameroon.

Equatorial Guinea



Area 10,830 sq miles
(28,051 sq km)
Population 700,000
Capital Malabo
Currency CFA franc
Official languages Spanish
and French
Life expectancy 51 years

Lying just north of the equator, Equatorial Guinea is made up of five islands and the territory of Río Muni on the west coast of Africa. The republic gained independence in 1968 after 190 years of Spanish rule. Equatorial Guinea is the only Spanish-speaking country in Africa.



Gabon



Area 103,347 sq miles
(267,667 sq km)
Population 1.5 million
Capital Libreville
Currency CFA franc
Official language French
Life expectancy 57 years

Gabon, located on the west coast of Africa, has some of the world's most unspoiled rainforests. It is also one of Africa's most urbanized countries. Gabon's economy is based on the production of oil, and the wealth from oil exports has given rise to an affluent middle class.



Congo



Area 132,047 sq miles
(342,000 sq km)
Population 4.1 million
Capital Brazzaville
Currency CFA franc
Official language French
Life expectancy 55 years

Congo lies along the equator in west central Africa. Marxist rule followed independence from France in 1960. However, the country became a multiparty democracy in 1991. Congo is one of the most urbanized countries in the region, with most people living in Brazzaville and Pointe-Noire.



São Tomé and Príncipe



Area 386 sq miles
(1,001 sq km)
Population 200,000
Capital São Tomé
Currency Dobra
Official language Portuguese
Life expectancy 65 years

Made up of two main islands and their surrounding islets, São Tomé and Príncipe was a Portuguese colony until 1975. It was a single-party Marxist nation until 1990, when multiparty democracy was adopted. Its population is 90 percent black African and 10 percent Portuguese and Creole.



▲ PARADISE ISLANDS
São Tomé and Príncipe is a traveler's paradise, with its palm-fringed beaches, crystal-clear water, and barely explored jungles.